

# Word family: cancel / cancelled / canceled / cancelling / canceling / cancellation / cancellable / cancelable / non-cancellable / non-cancelable

**Base word:** cancel

**Past / past participle:** cancelled/canceled

**-ing form:** cancelling/canceling

**Related forms:** cancellation, cancellable/cancelable

**Useful extensions:** noise-cancelling, active noise cancellation, echo cancellation, cancellation policy, cancellation fee, cancel culture

**Part of speech:** mainly verb (動詞), with noun/adjective family extensions

A full semantic sweep shows that **cancel** has one broad underlying concept:

**make something stop, no longer happen, no longer apply, or no longer have effect**

But there are several genuinely useful branches:

- cancel an event/appointment;
- cancel an order/reservation;
- cancel a subscription/service;
- cancel a payment/cheque/card;
- cancel noise/signals;
- cancel mathematical terms;
- invalidate stamps/tickets/documents;
- modern social-media use **cancel someone**.

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## Meaning in your original passage: noise-cancelling headphones

Your earlier phrase was:

“a pair of **noise-cancelling headphones**”

Here, **cancelling** means:

**reducing or neutralizing unwanted external sound so that much less of it reaches the listener.**

繁體中文：透過技術減弱、抵消或中和外界不想聽到的噪音

So:

**noise-cancelling headphones**

= 降噪耳機

More precisely:

**noise-cancelling** = 能主動減弱／抵消外界噪音的

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## 1. **cancel + event/meeting/appointment** (活動／會議／預約) — 取消；使不再舉行

**Meaning:** To decide that a planned event or arrangement will no longer happen.

### Practice 1

“They **cancelled** the meeting.”

「他們取消了會議，使會議不再舉行。」

### Practice 2

“The concert was **canceled** because of bad weather.”

「演唱會因天氣惡劣而被取消。」

**cancel an event** = 決定原本已安排的活動不再進行

This is one of the most common meanings.

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## 2. cancel + booking/reservation/order (預訂／訂單) — 取消預訂；取消訂單

This is closely related to #1, but commercially important enough to teach separately.

### Practice 3

“I had to **cancel my hotel reservation**.”

「我不得不取消酒店預訂。」

### Practice 4

“The customer **cancelled the order** before it was shipped.”

「顧客在貨物寄出之前取消了訂單。」

**cancel a booking/order** = 撤銷原本已作出的預訂或購買安排，使交易／安排不再繼續

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## 3. cancel + subscription/membership/service (訂閱／會籍／服務) — 終止；取消

Here, the arrangement may already be active.

### Practice 5

“I **cancelled my subscription** last month.”

「我上個月取消了訂閱／終止了訂閱服務。」

### Practice 6

“You can **cancel the service** at any time.”

「你可以隨時終止這項服務。」

**cancel a subscription/service** = 終止一項持續中的合約、訂閱或服務，使其之後不再生效／收費

This is slightly different from cancelling an event:

- event → stops before happening
  - subscription → ongoing arrangement is terminated
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## 4. **cancel + contract/agreement** (合約／協議) — 解除；終止

A more formal/legal/business use.

### Practice 7

“Either party may **cancel the contract** with thirty days’ notice.”

「任何一方都可以提前三十天通知以終止合約。」

### Practice 8

“The agreement was **cancelled** after both sides failed to reach a settlement.”

「雙方未能達成和解後，協議被終止／撤銷。」

**cancel a contract/agreement** = 正式終止原本具有法律或商業效力的安排

Depending on legal context, **terminate**, **rescind**, or **void** may be more precise than **cancel**.

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## 5. **cancel + payment/cheque/check** (付款／支票) — 撤銷；停止付款；使失效

### Practice 9

“He asked the bank to **cancel the payment**.”

「他要求銀行撤銷／停止那筆付款。」

### Practice 10

“She **cancelled the cheque** after realizing it had been lost.”

「她發現支票遺失後，便把支票作廢／停止支付。」

**cancel a payment/cheque** = 阻止原本安排的付款完成，或令付款工具失去效力

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## 6. **cancel + card/ticket/document**(卡／票／文件) — 使失效；作廢

**Meaning:** To officially make something no longer valid.

### Practice 11

“The bank **cancelled** the stolen card.”

「銀行把被盜的卡註銷／作廢。」

### Practice 12

“The ticket was **cancelled** after use.”

「那張票使用後被註銷／標示為失效。」

**cancel** = 正式令卡、票、文件等不再具有原來的有效性

This is related to stopping something from having effect, not to cancelling an event.

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## 7. **cancel noise/sound**(噪音／聲音) — 抵消；消除；中和

This is the meaning behind your **noise-cancelling headphones**.

### Practice 13

“The headphones use microphones to help **cancel external noise**.”

「耳機利用麥克風協助抵消外界噪音。」

### Practice 14

“The system generates an opposing signal to **cancel unwanted sound**.”

「系統產生相反的訊號來抵消不需要的聲音。」

**cancel noise** = 透過產生相反或抵消作用, 使不想要的聲音明顯減弱

Important: in real consumer products, **cancel** does not necessarily mean **100% remove every sound**.

Natural Chinese is usually:

降噪／抵消噪音

rather than literally 「取消噪音」.

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## 8. noise-cancelling = designed to reduce unwanted sound — 降噪的

This is your exact adjective form.

### Practice 15

“I bought **noise-cancelling headphones** for travelling.”

「我買了一副降噪耳機, 旅行時使用。」

### Practice 16

“Noise-cancelling technology is useful on airplanes.”

「降噪技術在飛機上很有用。」

**noise-cancelling** = 使用技術主動／被動減少外界噪音的

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## 9. active noise cancellation (ANC) — 主動降噪

A very useful technical family extension.

**Meaning:** Technology that detects external sound and generates an opposite sound wave to reduce it.

### Practice 17

“The headphones support **active noise cancellation**.”

「這副耳機支援主動降噪 (ANC)。」

### Practice 18

“Turning on **active noise cancellation** reduces low-frequency background noise.”

「開啟主動降噪功能可以減少低頻背景噪音。」

**active noise cancellation** = 偵測外界噪音後產生相反聲波，使部分噪音互相抵消的技術

This is distinct from passive isolation such as thick ear cushions.

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## 10. echo cancellation (通訊／音訊) — 回音消除；回聲消除

Another useful technology extension.

### Practice 19

“The software includes **echo cancellation** for video calls.”

「這套軟件包含視像通話用的回音消除功能。」

### Practice 20

“Better echo cancellation makes conversations clearer.”

「更好的回聲消除技術可以令通話更清晰。」

**echo cancellation** = 識別並減少通訊系統中不需要的回聲

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## 11. cancel + mathematical term/factor (數學) — 約去; 消去

A genuinely distinct technical meaning.

### Practice 21

“The common factors can be **cancelled**.”

「共同因數可以約去／消去。」

### Practice 22

“Cancel the x terms on both sides.”

「把兩邊的 x 項消去。」

**cancel — mathematics** = 把兩邊或分子分母中可互相抵消的相同項／因子消去，以簡化表達式

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## 12. cancel opposing effects/forces (作用／效果) — 互相抵消; 中和

A broader scientific/figurative extension.

### Practice 23

“The two forces **cancel** each other.”

「兩個力互相抵消。」

## Practice 24

“The benefits and disadvantages almost **cancel** each other.”

「優點和缺點幾乎互相抵消。」

**cancel** = 兩個相反作用彼此抵消，使總效果減少或接近零

Strictly speaking, **cancel each other** / **cancel each other out** is common; I'm including the non-phrasal core concept because it is a genuine meaning of **cancel**.

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## 13. **cancel someone** (現代社交／網絡語境) — 抵制；公開撤回支持

A modern informal meaning.

**Meaning:** To publicly withdraw support from a person, brand, or public figure because of behavior or statements considered objectionable.

## Practice 25

“Some users called for the celebrity to be **cancelled**.”

「有些網民呼籲抵制那位名人／停止支持他。」

## Practice 26

“The brand faced calls to be **canceled** after the controversy.”

「爭議發生後，有人呼籲抵制該品牌並停止支持它。」

**cancel someone** = 因認為某人的言行不可接受，而公開停止支持、關注或消費其作品／產品

Register: informal, contemporary, culturally loaded.

This is not literally the same as cancelling a booking.

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## 14. cancel culture — 取消文化；網絡抵制文化

A useful modern family extension.

### Practice 27

“The debate about **cancel culture** often focuses on accountability and free expression.”

「關於取消文化／網絡抵制文化的討論，常涉及問責與言論自由。」

### Practice 28

“The term ‘cancel culture’ is used differently by different speakers.”

「不同說話者對『取消文化』這個詞的使用方式並不完全相同。」

**cancel culture** = 透過公開批評、抵制或撤回支持，對被認為有問題的言行作出社會性回應的現象

Because the term itself is contested, it is best treated descriptively rather than as a value judgment.

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## 15. cancellation = act/result of cancelling something — 取消；撤銷；終止

This is the main noun.

### Practice 29

“We received notice of the **cancellation** of the flight.”

「我們收到航班取消通知。」

### Practice 30

“Early **cancellation** may involve a fee.”

「提早取消／終止服務可能需要支付費用。」

**cancellation** = 某個活動、安排、服務或權利被正式停止／撤銷這件事

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## 16. **cancellation** = cancelled event/booking (被取消事項) — 取消名額; 被取消的預約

Sometimes a **cancellation** refers to the actual cancelled booking/event slot.

### Practice 31

“The restaurant had a last-minute **cancellation**.”

「餐廳臨時有一個取消了的訂位／空出的名額。」

### Practice 32

“We got an appointment because of a **cancellation**.”

「因為有人取消預約而空出名額，我們才約到時間。」

**a cancellation** = 原本已安排但後來被取消的一個預約／名額

This is especially common in:

- restaurants
  - doctors
  - hotels
  - salons
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## 17. **cancellation policy** (商業／預訂) — 取消政策

### Practice 33

“Check the hotel’s **cancellation policy** before booking.”

「預訂前先查看酒店的取消政策。」

### Practice 34

“The cancellation policy allows free changes up to 24 hours before arrival.”

「取消政策允許在抵達前 24 小時免費更改。」

**cancellation policy** = 規定客戶何時及以甚麼條件可以取消預訂／服務的規則

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## 18. **cancellation fee** (費用) — 取消費; 取消手續費

### Practice 35

“The airline charged a **cancellation fee**.”

「航空公司收取了取消手續費。」

### Practice 36

“There is no cancellation fee if you cancel within 24 hours.”

「如果你在 24 小時內取消，就不用支付取消費。」

**cancellation fee** = 因撤銷預訂、服務或合約而收取的費用

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## 19. **cancellable / cancelable** = able to be cancelled — 可取消的; 可撤銷的

Both spellings occur.

### Practice 37

“The booking is fully **cancellable**.”

「這項預訂可以完全取消。」

### Practice 38

“This ticket is **cancelable** without a fee.”

「這張票可以免費取消。」

**cancellable/cancelable** = 規則或系統允許之後撤銷／取消的

Spelling:

- **cancellable** is especially common in British English
  - **cancelable** is common in American English
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## 20. **non-cancellable / non-cancelable** = **cannot be cancelled** — 不可取消的；不可撤銷的

### Practice 39

“The discounted reservation is **non-cancellable**.”

「這項折扣預訂是不可取消的。」

### Practice 40

“The ticket is non-cancelable and non-refundable.”

「這張票不可取消，也不可退款。」

**non-cancellable** = 一旦預訂／購買後，按規則不能再撤銷的

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**Important spelling distinction: cancelled/cancelling vs  
canceled/canceling**

## British English

- cancelled
- cancelling
- cancellation

## American English

- canceled
- canceling
- cancellation

Notice:

**cancellation** normally has **double l** in both major varieties.

That is a useful spelling trap.

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## Important distinction: cancel vs postpone

### cancel

= it will not happen as planned.

“The concert was cancelled.”

「演唱會取消了。」

### postpone

= it will happen later.

“The concert was postponed until Friday.”

「演唱會延期至星期五。」

So:

**cancel** = 不舉行／終止

**postpone** = 延期，但仍預計會舉行

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## Important distinction: cancel vs reschedule

### **cancel**

= remove the existing arrangement.

### **reschedule**

= arrange a different time/date.

“I cancelled the appointment.”

「我取消了預約。」

“I rescheduled the appointment for Monday.”

「我把預約改到星期一。」

You may first cancel one appointment and then reschedule it, but the words are not identical.

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## Important distinction: cancel vs terminate

### **cancel**

broad, everyday.

### **terminate**

more formal and often used for ongoing:

- contracts
- employment
- services
- agreements.

“cancel a subscription”

very natural.

“terminate a contract”

more formal/legal.

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## Important distinction: cancel vs delete

Especially in technology.

### **cancel**

= stop an operation before it completes.

“Cancel the download.”

「取消下載。」

### **delete**

= remove data/file that exists.

“Delete the file.”

「刪除檔案。」

So:

**cancel ≠ delete**

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## Important distinction: cancel vs refund

### **cancel**

= end/revoke the booking/order.

### **refund**

= return the money.

A booking can be:

**cancelled but non-refundable**

= 取消了，但不退款

Very useful consumer-English distinction.

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## Important distinction: cancel vs void

### **cancel**

broad: stop, revoke, terminate.

### **void**

formal/legal/accounting:  
make something legally or officially invalid.

“The cheque was voided.”

「支票被作廢。」

They can overlap, but **void** emphasizes invalidity.

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## Important distinction: noise cancellation vs noise isolation

Especially important for your headphones.

### **noise cancellation**

uses technology—especially active processing—to reduce incoming noise.

### **noise isolation**

physically blocks sound through:

- ear cups,
- seals,
- padding.

So:

**active noise cancellation (ANC)**

= 主動降噪

**passive noise isolation**

= 被動隔音

They are not the same technology.

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## **Important distinction: noise-cancelling vs noise-canceling**

Both spellings are correct depending on variety/style.

### **British-oriented spelling:**

**noise-cancelling**

### **American-oriented spelling:**

**noise-canceling**

Your passage uses:

**noise-cancelling headphones**

which is fully natural British-style spelling.

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## **Family-extension sweep**

After the full sweep, the useful modern family includes:

- **cancel an event** = 取消活動
- **cancel an appointment/booking** = 取消預約／預訂
- **cancel an order** = 取消訂單
- **cancel a subscription/service** = 終止訂閱／服務
- **cancel a contract** = 終止／撤銷合約
- **cancel a payment/cheque** = 撤銷付款／使支票失效
- **cancel a card/ticket** = 註銷／作廢
- **cancel noise** = 抵消／減弱噪音
- **noise-cancelling** = 降噪的
- **active noise cancellation** = 主動降噪
- **echo cancellation** = 回音消除
- **cancel — mathematics** = 約去／消去

- **cancel opposing effects** = 互相抵消
- **cancel someone** = 公開撤回支持／抵制
- **cancel culture** = 取消文化／網絡抵制文化
- **cancellation** = 取消／撤銷／終止
- **a cancellation** = 被取消的預約／空出名額
- **cancellation policy** = 取消政策
- **cancellation fee** = 取消費
- **cancellable/cancelable** = 可取消的
- **non-cancellable/non-cancelable** = 不可取消的

I would exclude obscure historical/legal senses beyond these unless a later passage specifically requires them.

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## Master comparison

| Form / sense                         | MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>cancel an event</b>               | 決定原本安排的活動不再舉行                         |
| <b>cancel a booking/order</b>        | 撤銷原本作出的預訂或購買安排                        |
| <b>cancel a subscription/service</b> | 終止持續中的訂閱、會籍或服務                        |
| <b>cancel a contract</b>             | 正式終止原本有效的合約／協議                        |
| <b>cancel a payment/cheque</b>       | 阻止付款完成或令付款工具失去效力                      |
| <b>cancel a card/ticket/document</b> | 正式令原本有效的卡、票或文件作廢                      |
| <b>cancel noise/sound</b>            | 透過抵消作用令不想要的聲音明顯減弱                     |
| <b>noise-cancelling</b>              | 能主動／被動減少外界噪音的                         |
| <b>active noise cancellation</b>     | 偵測噪音並產生反向聲波以減弱噪音的技術                   |
| <b>echo cancellation</b>             | 識別並減少通訊系統中不需要的回聲                      |
| <b>cancel — mathematics</b>          | 把可互相抵消的相同項／因子消去以簡化運算                  |
| <b>cancel opposing effects</b>       | 兩個相反作用彼此抵消，使總效果減少／接近零                 |

|                               |                               |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| <b>cancel someone</b>         | 因其言行被認為有問題而公開撤回支持、關注或消費       |
| <b>cancel culture</b>         | 透過公開批評、抵制或撤回支持回應被認為有問題言行的社會現象 |
| <b>cancellation</b>           | 某項活動、預訂、服務或權利被正式停止／撤銷         |
| <b>a cancellation</b>         | 一個原本已安排但後來被取消的預約／名額           |
| <b>cancellable/cancelable</b> | 規則允許之後撤銷或取消的                  |
| <b>non-cancellable</b>        | 一旦安排／購買後按規則不能再取消的             |

### For your original phrase

“a pair of **noise-cancelling headphones**”

The exact meaning is:

**cancelling** = 透過耳機的設計／電子技術減弱或抵消外界不想聽到的噪音

So naturally:

**noise-cancelling headphones**

= 降噪耳機

And this redo is a good example of why the Family Sweep matters: **cancel** is far richer than just 「取消」—your own passage actually uses the **acoustic** “抵消噪音” meaning rather than the ordinary “cancel an appointment” meaning.